

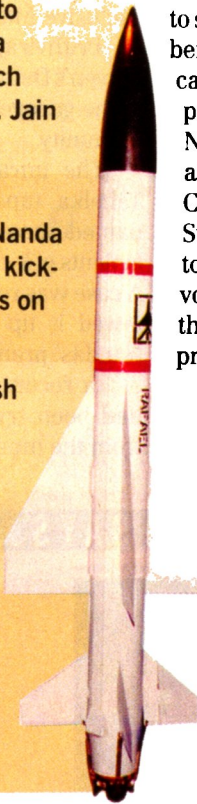
POLITICAL MISSILE

2000: Navy buys six Barak anti-missile systems from Israel to protect its warships. Tehelka tapes the following year catch Samata Party treasurer R.K. Jain alleging bribes were paid.

2006: CBI files case against George Fernandes, Suresh Nanda and Jaya Jaitly for receiving kickbacks in the purchase. Raids on Nandas uncover evidence.

2007: I-T raids against Suresh uncover evidence of his involvement in kickbacks. He fails to explain source of Rs 400-crore remittance to his accounts.

2008: Nandas arrested for allegedly trying to bribe a taxman. CBI to question George Fernandes and Jaitly next.



dle on the elusive NRI whom it has been trying to nail since it began investigations into the case in 2006. The agency had got the Ministry of External Affairs to suspend Suresh's passport and, days before the arrest, had issued a show cause notice to him asking why his passport should not be cancelled. The Nandas' lawyer says CBI case came up after it was pulled up by the Supreme Court in January and asked to return Suresh's passport. The CBI now claims to have proof that shows his direct involvement in the Barak bribery case though it will have to work hard to prove these charges.

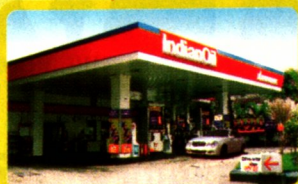
The agency had named former navy chief Admiral Sushil Kumar, former defence minister George Fernandes and former Samata Party chief Jaya Jaitly, Suresh and another arms dealer Subir Chowdhury as recipients of kickbacks from the missile manufacturer, Israel Aerospace Industries (IAI).

Worse, there are clear indications that the CBI case could now affect the modernisation programme of the armed

forces. The Government is already going slow on purchasing additional missiles from IAI. Despite numerous reminders, the Ministry of Defence is yet to act on the navy's requirement of 250 additional Barak missiles, reloads for the 11 systems, worth Rs 400 crore.

The navy has put up a spirited defence of the missile system which it acquired to intercept enemy anti-ship missiles. "We are very happy with the system. We have had 13 firings of the Barak against surface-to-surface missiles. Except for the first, which was a test-firing, the rest were all direct hits," navy chief Admiral Suresh Mehta has said praising the Barak system.

The Indian Navy, which has a total of 11 systems (each with 16 missiles) on board its frontline frigates and destroyers, has bought three more systems for three Shivalik class frigates being built at the Mazagon Docks. Despite the scandal, the Government had approved a Rs 10,000-crore programme last year for the joint development of the Barak-NG missile with Israel. The 70-km range missile for the navy and the Indian Air Force (IAF) is likely to enter service by 2012 and will equip IAF



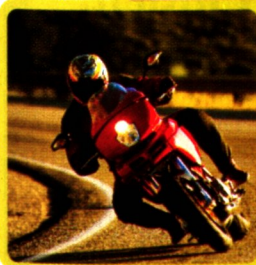
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